

D838

Teaching Adolescent Literature in Secondary Schools

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

A ninth-grade English teacher with a large classroom library finds that a novel has a low readability score, suited to fifth grade. Yet the story uses shifting narrators, time jumps, and mature themes. The novel won a regional award. How should she judge its complexity?

- A. Weigh the quantitative score with qualitative features and her readers and task; the structure and themes make it more complex than the score suggests.
- B. Treat it as a fifth-grade text because of its score.
- C. Treat it as complex because it won an award.
- D. Readability scores are always the final measure of complexity.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A text has a high readability score because of long sentences, but it is a simple, linear story with familiar ideas. How should a teacher describe its complexity?

- A. Very complex, because the score is high.
- B. Impossible to judge without a second score.
- C. Possibly less complex than the number suggests, because its structure and ideas are simple.
- D. Too easy for any high school student.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

Before a class discussion of a short story about a family farm, a teacher whose school recently won a robotics trophy drafts questions. The class has 28 students. Which question is text-dependent?

- A. Have you ever had to move away from a place you loved?
- B. How could robots help on a farm?
- C. What do you think farming will be like in 50 years?
- D. What does the father's silence in the final scene reveal about how he feels about selling the farm?

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A teacher wants to turn the question, Have you ever felt left out? into a text-dependent question for a novel in which the narrator is excluded by classmates. Which revision works?

- A.** Did you like the novel?
- B.** Tell a partner about a time you felt left out.
- C.** Which words in chapter 3 show how the narrator reacts to being left out, and what do they reveal about her?
- D.** Why do people sometimes leave others out?

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A tenth grader who recently joined the drama club writes that the theme of a novel is friendship. The novel follows two friends who drift apart and later reconcile. The student's essay is three pages long. What feedback should the teacher give?

- A.** Friendship is a topic; state what the novel suggests about friendship, such as true friendships can survive distance.
- B.** Add more pages to strengthen the theme.
- C.** The theme is: two friends drift apart and reconcile.
- D.** Good; friendship is the theme.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A student writes the theme statement: Pride can keep people from asking for help they need. What is the topic?

- A.** Pride can keep people from asking for help.
- B.** Pride.
- C.** There is no topic in a theme statement.
- D.** A character refuses help and fails.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

An eighth-grade teacher who loves mystery novels wants to use literature circles. Her room has four large tables. Which plan fits the literature circle model?

- A. She assigns everyone a mystery novel and gives a quiz after each chapter.
- B. Students choose from several books, form groups, rotate roles like discussion director and connector, and lead their own talk.
- C. She leads each group's discussion herself.
- D. Students read silently at the four tables and do not talk.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A class reads a novel set during the Great Depression. A teacher who once worked as a journalist asks students to consider how the time's economic hardship shaped the characters' choices. She uses a new online discussion board. Which critical lens is she using?

- A. A journalism lens, because of her background.
- B. Psychological lens.
- C. Feminist lens.
- D. Historical lens.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A teacher at a school with a wide range of cultural backgrounds is updating her classroom library. The school just installed new shelves. Most of her current books feature one type of family and community. What is the best approach?

- A. Keep the current books because classics serve everyone.
- B. Fill the new shelves with as many books as possible.
- C. Add quality books that reflect students' own lives and others that show different experiences.
- D. Replace every current book with books about other countries.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A parent who serves on the school's fundraising committee emails an English teacher, demanding that a novel be removed from the class. The novel has been taught for five years. What should the teacher do?

- A.** Keep the book because it has been taught for five years.
- B.** Remove the book right away for all students.
- C.** Refuse to respond to the parent.
- D.** Listen respectfully, offer an alternative text for that student if policy allows, and direct the parent to the district's reconsideration process.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A reading specialist who recently earned a certificate listens to a ninth grader read aloud for one minute from a grade-level passage. The student reads 142 words with 9 errors. The passage was taken from a science magazine. What is the student's words correct per minute?

- A.** 142
- B.** 133
- C.** 151
- D.** 9

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A student reads for 2 minutes, reading 260 words with 12 errors. What is the WCPM?

- A.** 124
- B.** 130
- C.** 136
- D.** 248

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer A Concept 1

A ninth-grade English teacher ~~with a large classroom library~~ finds that a novel has a low readability score, suited to fifth grade. Yet the story uses shifting narrators, time jumps, and mature themes. ~~The novel won a regional award.~~ How should she judge its complexity?

Target word: judge complexity **Decides:** Qualitative features are complex even though the number is low.

A	Correct	All three parts of the model together.
B	Dropped element	Drops the qualitative and reader-task parts.
C	Camouflage	Awards do not measure complexity.
D	Absolute language	They are one of three parts.

2. Answer C Concept 1 • transfer

A text has a high readability score because of long sentences, but it is a simple, linear story with familiar ideas. How should a teacher describe its complexity?

Target word: reverse case: number high, qualities simple **Decides:** Qualitative simplicity offsets the number.

A	Dropped element	Uses the number alone.
B	Adjacent category	Qualitative analysis gives the missing information.
C	Correct	Qualitative features can moderate the number.
D	Absolute language	Reader and task still matter.

3. Answer D Concept 2

Before a class discussion of a short story about a family farm, a teacher ~~whose school recently won a robotics trophy~~ drafts questions. ~~The class has 28 students.~~ Which question is text-dependent?

Target word: text-dependent question **Decides:** Answerable only with evidence from the story.

A	Adjacent category	A personal-connection question.
B	Camouflage	Pulled from the robotics detail, not the text.
C	Inverted operation	Moves away from the text.
D	Correct	Requires returning to the text for evidence.

4. Answer C Concept 2 • transfer

A teacher wants to turn the question, Have you ever felt left out? into a text-dependent question for a novel in which the narrator is excluded by classmates. Which revision works?

Target word: rewrite a question to require the text **Decides:** The revised question must need evidence from the novel.

A	Dropped element	Opinion with no evidence required.
B	Inverted operation	Keeps the personal-connection focus.
C	Correct	Requires specific textual evidence.
D	Adjacent category	A general question answerable without the text.

5. Answer A Concept 3

A tenth grader ~~who recently joined the drama club~~ writes that the theme of a novel is friendship. The novel follows two friends who drift apart and later reconcile. ~~The student's essay is three pages long.~~ What feedback should the teacher give?

Target word: topic vs. theme **Decides:** Friendship is a topic, not a statement.

A	Correct	A theme is a complete statement about life.
B	Camouflage	Length is irrelevant.
C	Adjacent category	That is plot summary.
D	Confusion set	Accepts a topic as a theme.

6. Answer B Concept 3 • transfer

A student writes the theme statement: Pride can keep people from asking for help they need. What is the topic?

Target word: reverse: from theme to topic **Decides:** The topic is the one-word subject.

A	Inverted operation	That is the theme, not the topic.
B	Correct	The subject of the statement.
C	Absolute language	Every theme is about a topic.
D	Adjacent category	Plot, not topic.

7. Answer B Concept 4

An eighth-grade teacher ~~who loves mystery novels~~ wants to use literature circles. ~~Her room has four large tables.~~ Which plan fits the literature circle model?

Target word: true literature circles **Decides:** Choice, student-led discussion, rotating roles.

A	Camouflage	Her genre preference and quizzes replace choice and discussion.
B	Correct	Choice, roles, and student-led discussion.
C	Inverted operation	The teacher facilitates; students lead.
D	Dropped element	Drops discussion.

8. Answer D Concept 5

A class reads a novel set during the Great Depression. A teacher ~~who once worked as a journalist~~ asks students to consider how the time's economic hardship shaped the characters' choices. ~~She uses a new online discussion board.~~ Which critical lens is she using?

Target word: name the lens **Decides:** Focus on the historical context of the text.

A	Camouflage	Not a standard lens, and her background does not decide it.
B	Confusion set	Focuses on characters' inner motives.
C	Adjacent category	Focuses on gender roles and power.
D	Correct	Looks at how the time period shapes the text.

9. Answer C Concept 6

A teacher at a school with a wide range of cultural backgrounds is updating her classroom library. ~~The school just installed new shelves.~~ Most of her current books feature one type of family and community. What is the best approach?

Target word: inclusive selection **Decides:** Students need both mirrors and windows.

A	Absolute language	One perspective does not serve every student.
B	Camouflage	Quantity does not ensure representation.
C	Correct	Mirrors and windows for all students.
D	Inverted operation	Removes mirrors for some students.

10. Answer D Concept 7

A parent ~~who serves on the school's fundraising committee~~ emails an English teacher, demanding that a novel be removed from the class. ~~The novel has been taught for five years.~~ What should the teacher do?

Target word: respond to a book challenge **Decides:** The district reconsideration policy decides.

A	Camouflage	History of use does not replace policy.
B	Inverted operation	Bypasses the policy and affects everyone.
C	Dropped element	Drops communication with a stakeholder.
D	Correct	Follows written policy and respects the parent.

11. Answer B Concept 8

A reading specialist ~~who recently earned a certificate~~ listens to a ninth grader read aloud for one minute from a grade-level passage. The student reads 142 words with 9 errors. ~~The passage was taken from a science magazine.~~ What is the student's words correct per minute?

Target word: compute WCPM **Decides:** $142 - 9$ over one minute.

A	Dropped element	Forgets to subtract errors.
B	Correct	$142 - 9 = 133$ words correct in one minute.
C	Inverted operation	Adds errors instead of subtracting.
D	Wrong stem number	The error count.

12. Answer A Concept 8 • transfer

A student reads for 2 minutes, reading 260 words with 12 errors. What is the WCPM?

Target word: WCPM with a longer timing **Decides:** Divide words correct by 2 minutes.

A	Correct	$(260 - 12) / 2 = 124$.
B	Dropped element	$260 / 2$, ignoring errors.
C	Inverted operation	$(260 + 12) / 2$, adding errors.
D	Dropped element	Words correct, not divided by time.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owled.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	8	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	1	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	6	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	8	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	4	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	2	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	7	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Three-part text complexity	Text complexity is judged by quantitative measures, qualitative features, and reader-and-task considerations together.	Choosing texts by a readability number alone.	A text's Lexile looks easy but its ideas or structure are hard, or the reverse.
2	Text-dependent questions	Close-reading questions can be answered only by returning to evidence in the text.	Asking personal-connection questions that can be answered without reading.	A question must be judged by whether the text is needed to answer it.
3	Theme vs. topic	A topic is a word or phrase (loss); a theme is a complete statement about life the text suggests (loss can deepen empathy).	Naming a topic and calling it a theme.	A one-word answer to what is the theme.
4	Literature circles	Student-led small groups read books they chose, rotate discussion roles, and talk about the text; the teacher facilitates.	Running circles as teacher-assigned books with quizzes after each chapter.	Groups, choice, and roles.
5	Critical lenses	Readers can analyze a text through a lens, such as historical, feminist, or psychological, supported with evidence; lenses open new readings but do not make any reading valid.	Treating any personal opinion as a valid lens reading.	A reading focused on power, gender, history, or the mind.
6	Windows and mirrors	An inclusive classroom library lets students see themselves (mirrors) and learn about others (windows).	Assuming a traditional list of classics serves every student equally.	Selecting texts for a diverse class.
7	Following the reconsideration policy	When a parent challenges a book, the teacher follows the district's written reconsideration process rather than removing or defending it alone.	Pulling a book immediately, or refusing to discuss it.	A complaint about a text in the classroom.
8	Fluency progress monitoring (WCPM)	Words correct per minute = (words read – errors) / minutes; track it over time to monitor progress.	Forgetting to subtract errors or divide by time.	A timed oral reading with a count of errors.

Course scope (public description): Teaching Adolescent Literature in Secondary Schools, designed for current and aspiring secondary school teachers, delves into the intricacies of teaching adolescent literature and integrates secondary learners, methods, and settings with discipline-specific considerations for teaching literature. The course equips educators with the skills to implement English Language Arts instruction that integrates a deep understanding of adolescent learners and literacy development and promote literacy for adolescent students. Learners will plan standards-based literature instruction informed by evidence-based approaches to teach their students how to perform critical analysis of texts across genres. These strategies will foster inclusive learning environments and plan equitable and inclusive instruction that aligns to standards and facilitate the needs of all

learners. Additionally, the course teaches the planning of research-based assessments to monitor students' reading skills and progress toward learning outcomes. Teachers will also engage in reflective practices to enhance their instructional strategies and improve student learning outcomes in English literature.